



BROTHERS RANJIT SINGH (L), CHANDER PRAKASH (R) WITH THEIR WIFE SUNITA DEVI AND CHILDREN, VILLAGE BONING SARING, SANGLA VALLEY, KINNAUR DISTRICT
Sunita feels lucky to have the affection of two husbands—Ranjit, a part-time postman, and Chander, who runs a grocery shop. They think nothing about sharing a wife.



our family would have spread but the land would have shrunk. Having a common wife has saved us from penury," says Namgayal.

If economic sustenance was the *raison d'être* for siblings sharing a wife in the past, the practice has meant a big economic spin-off for many. Half a century into sharing his wife, Ram Bhagati, 59, with his brother Himmat Singh, 55, Lakshman Singh Negi, 70, waxes eloquent on the virtues of polyandry. The two brothers, who had inherited 25 bighas of ancestral land in Kuppa village in Sangla Valley, are today a picture of prosperity, owning 80 bighas of apple orchards, a string of properties and a flourishing fruit trading business in Chandigarh. All their eight children—four sons and four daughters—are well-placed in government jobs and private enterprises. "The common marriage has kept our family together and multiplied our fortune," says portly Negi,

supervising the construction of his latest venture, a hotel near Sangla.

The extreme form of fraternal polyandry in which four to five siblings have a common wife is now mainly confined to the remote interiors of Pooh and Yangthang areas of upper Kinnaur, but elsewhere the practice has evolved into a more practical equation of two brothers sharing a spouse. Rattan Singh, 43, a boxing coach with the Indo-Tibetan Border Police, and his brother Jogdayal, 41, entered into wedlock with Sumriti Devi in 1989. While Rattan, a graduate, has taken upon himself the responsibility of the education of their four common children, Jogdayal looks after the family orchard back home in Kafnu village.